

Keep the door open.

Helping every young person succeed in second-level education and navigate a future beyond it.

An Irish post-primary workshop for teachers, year heads and school leaders



Before the data, a person.

01

What was assumed.

The label, expectation or limit placed on me.

02

What changed.

The adult action, opportunity or standard that shifted the path.

03

What opened.

The choice, confidence or future that became possible.

Who changed your odds?

01

Who noticed?

Who saw more than the label, result or difficult week?

02

What repeated?

What did they keep doing - quietly, reliably, more than once?

03

What opened?

Which choice, confidence or future became easier to imagine?

Think privately. If invited, share the practice - not the person.

One in seven.

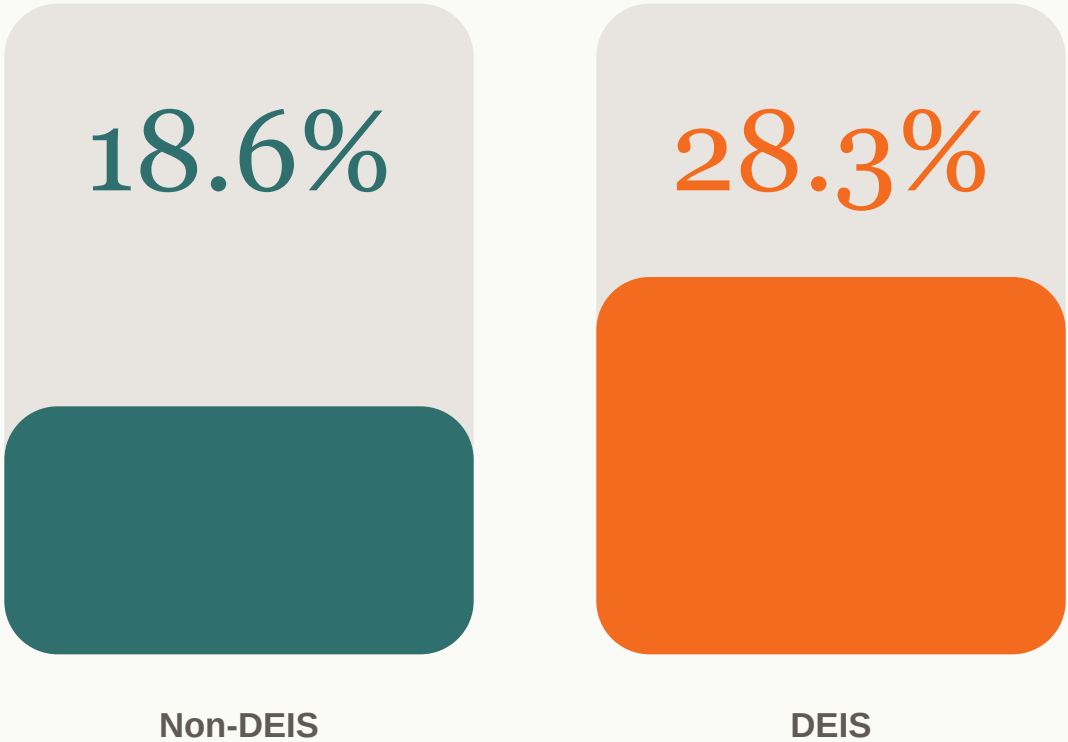
13.8%

of children lived in households experiencing child-specific enforced deprivation in 2024.

This measure means a household could not afford at least three of 17 child-specific essentials or activities.

**It is a description of conditions around childhood
- not a description of a child's capacity.**

Absence compounds quietly.



THE REPORTED GAP

9.7 percentage points separate the two rates.

20+ days is about four school weeks. Support should begin when the pattern emerges.

Progress is real. The remaining gap is real.



The DEIS/non-DEIS retention gap narrowed from **16.8** to **8.7** percentage points.

Background shifts the odds. It does not write the outcome.

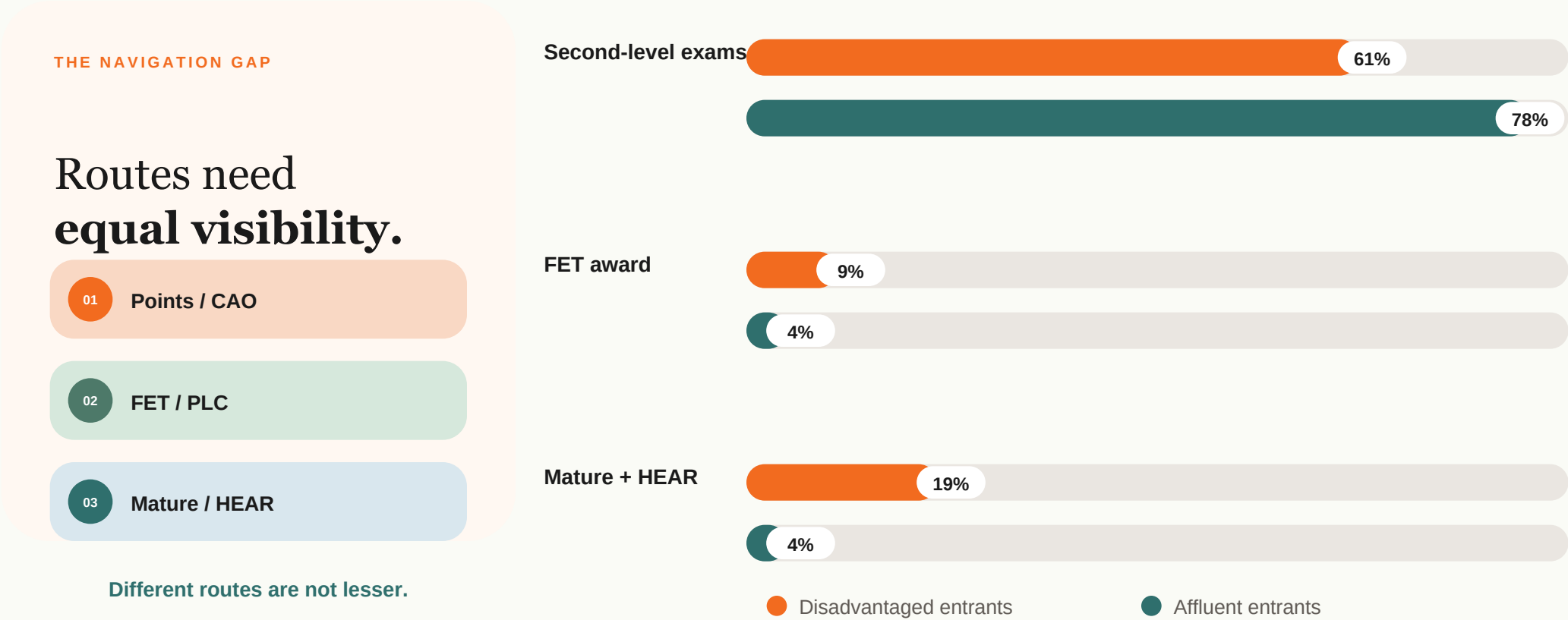
74

maths points separated Ireland's most and least socio-economically advantaged quarters in PISA 2022.

12%

of disadvantaged students were academically resilient - scoring in Ireland's top quarter.

The route into higher education is uneven.



Data can sharpen action - or harden a stereotype.

THE QUICK CONCLUSION

“They do not value school.”

“The family will not engage.”

“Not college material.”

“Trauma explains the behaviour.”

THE USEFUL QUESTION

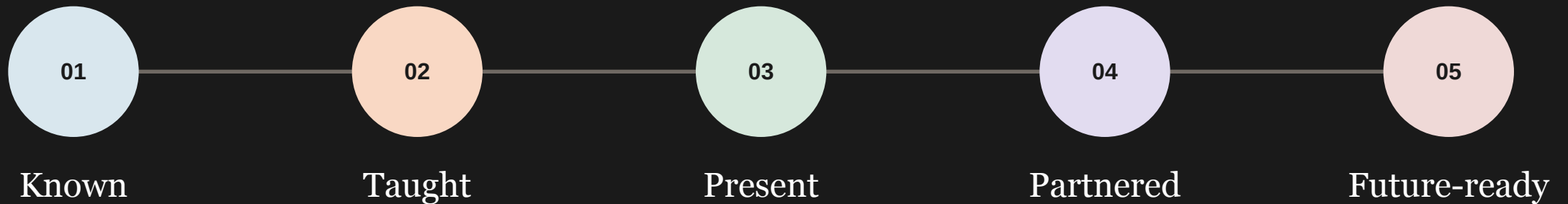
“What makes attendance harder here?”

“How accessible and trustworthy is our contact?”

“Which routes and supports are still invisible?”

“What supports regulation and a return to learning?”

Five promises that change the odds.



Not five programmes. Five dependable experiences of school.

Relationships are learning infrastructure.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE POINTS TO

Positive teacher-student relationships at age 13 were especially important in the later attainment of economically vulnerable young people.

School cannot remove every external pressure.
It can make sure no student becomes invisible.

01

Name

One reliable adult the student can identify.

02

Notice

Absence, withdrawal and change trigger contact.

03

Repair

Conflict has a dignified route back to learning.

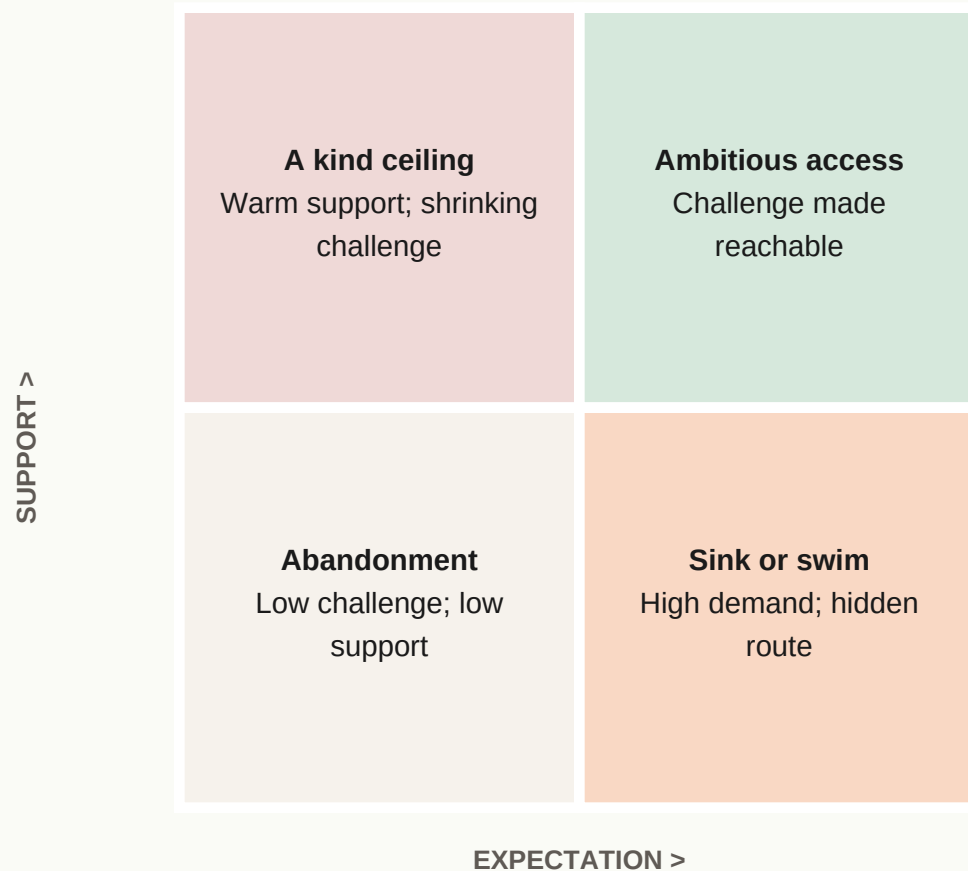
04

Record

Support begins with strengths and what works.

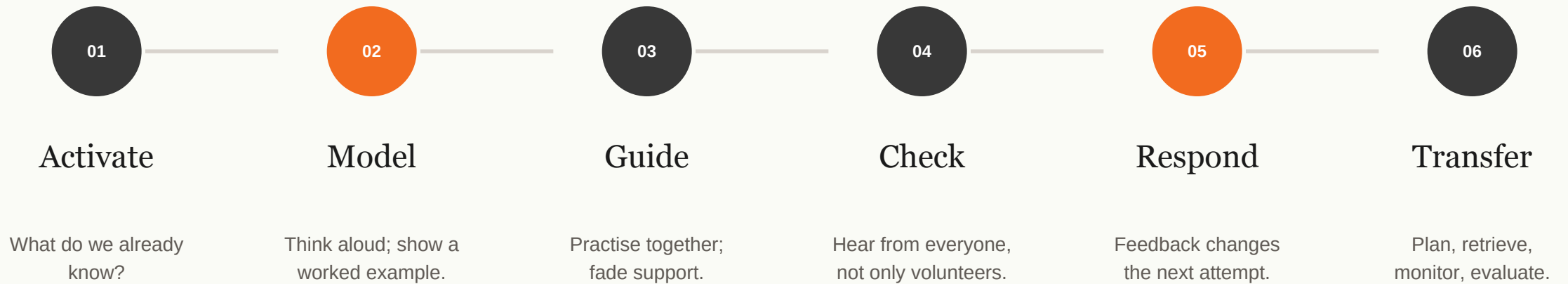
Belonging is not an extra programme. It is how learning stays reachable.

High expectations need high support.



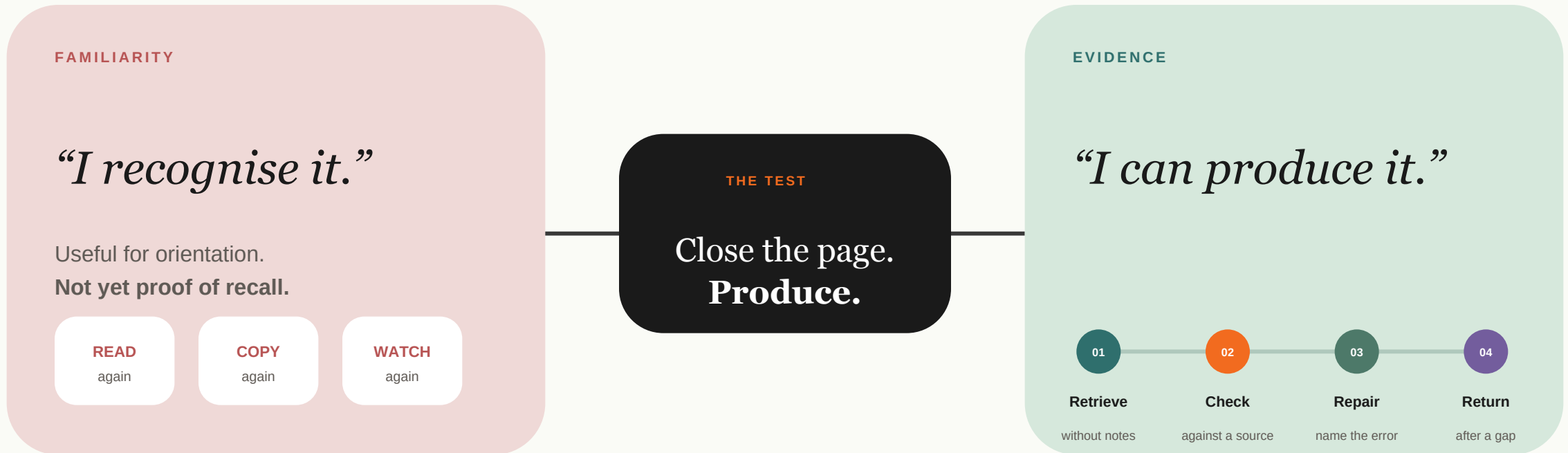
The goal is not “be tougher.”
The goal is to make
ambitious work **legible,**
scaffolded and
attainable.

Teach the route, not only the destination.



Metacognition works best inside subject teaching: model how an expert plans, monitors and evaluates a real task.

Studying is not the same as learning.



Input can orient. Evidence shows what survived when the page disappeared.

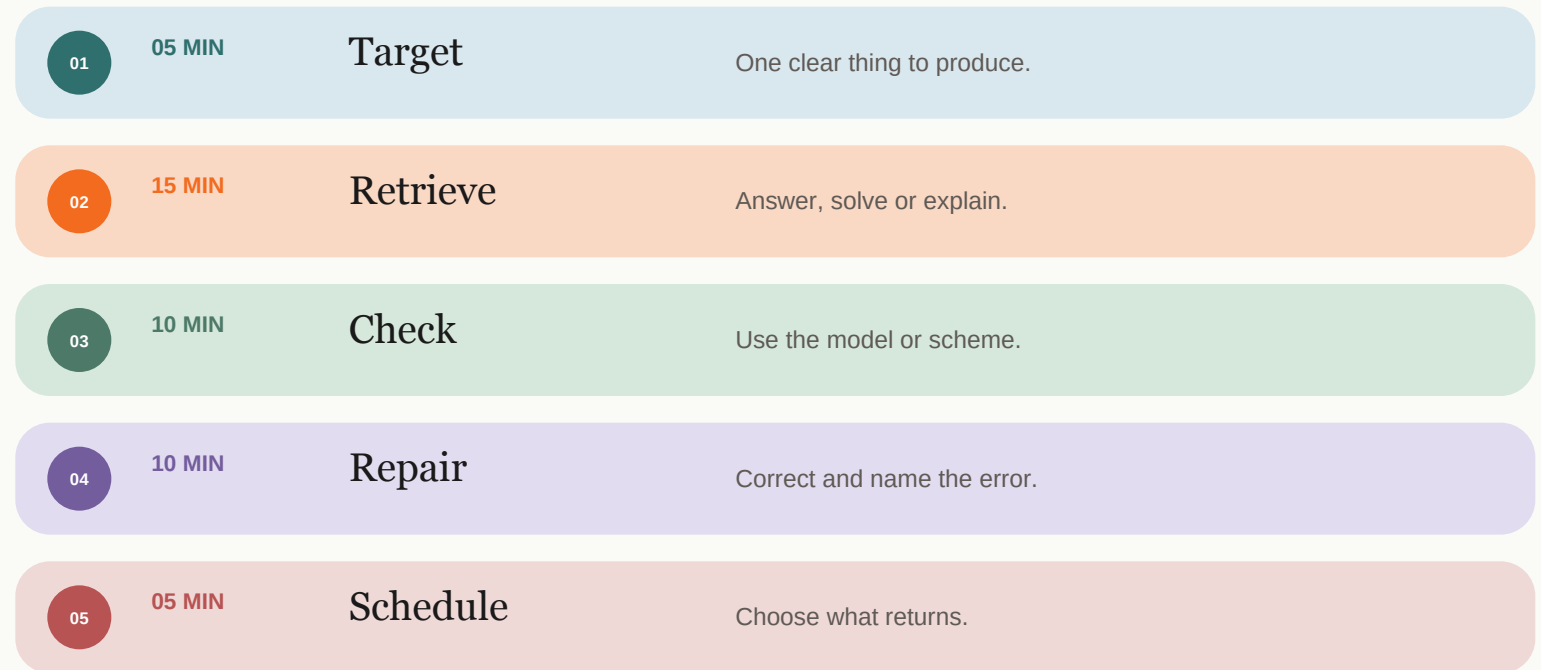
A study session needs an ending, not just a timer.

ONE PRACTICAL SHAPE

45

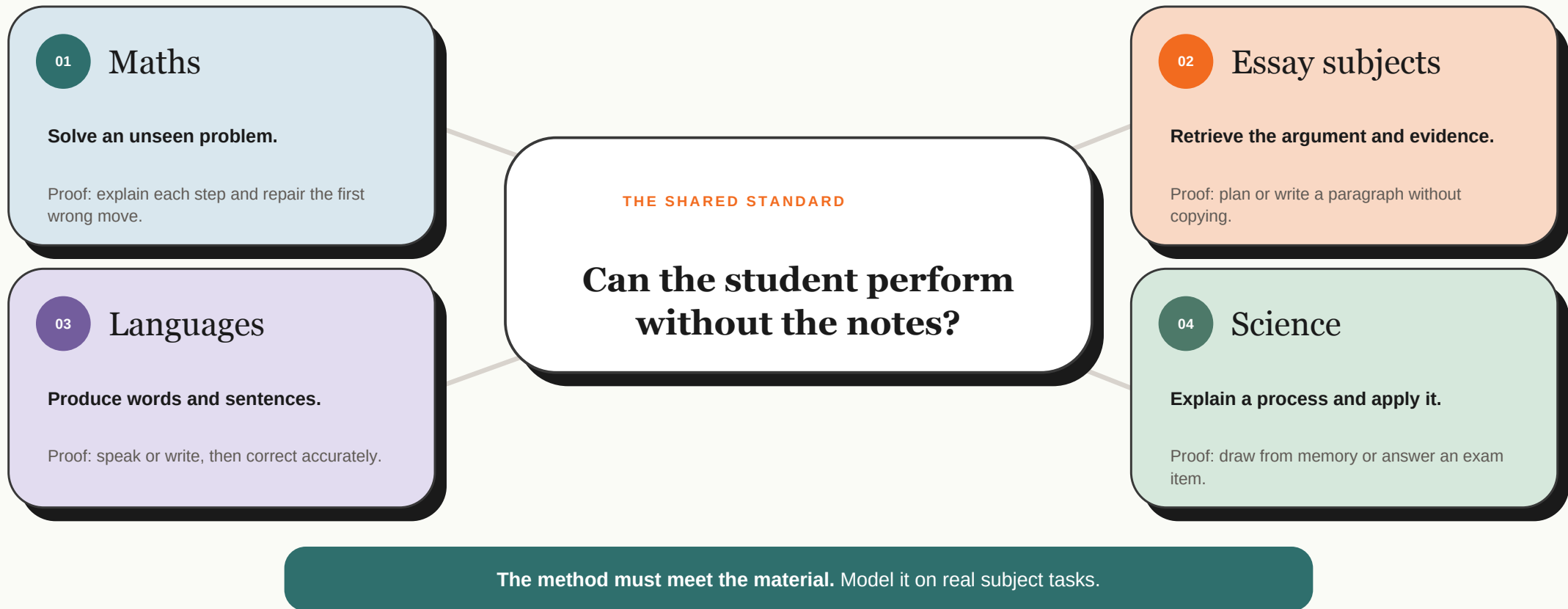
MINUTES

The time can flex.
The sequence cannot.



Target → retrieve → check → repair → return.

Good study changes with the subject.



Do not make success depend on a quiet bedroom.

THE EQUITY TEST



Could the student use this method **without** private tuition, their own device or an expert adult at home?

Access is part of pedagogy.

WHAT SCHOOL CAN MAKE DEPENDABLE

01

A predictable, supervised study slot

02

Device, print, books and mark-scheme access

03

A modelled routine using real subject work

04

A low-noise place to retrieve and practise

05

Rapid feedback and one visible next step

Care without lowering the ceiling.

Respond to what is observable. Refer what is not ours to assess.

STABILITY WE CAN DESIGN

Dignity and challenge, held together.

- 01 **Predictability** routines and transitions
- 02 **Choice** within clear boundaries
- 03 **Regulate** before reasoning
- 04 **Return** a dignified route back
- 05 **Refer** through the support system

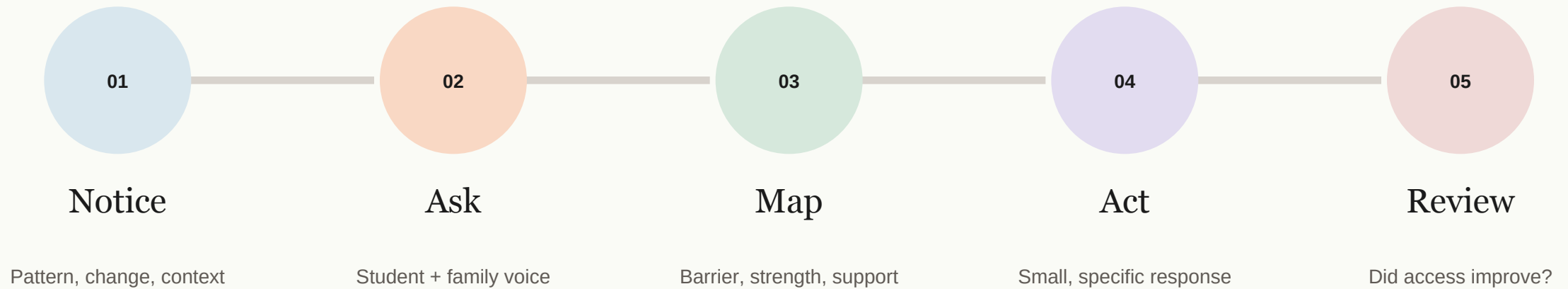
LINES WE DO NOT CROSS

Support the behaviour. Do not invent the history.

- **ACE scores** do not collect or display
- **Diagnosis** do not infer from behaviour
- **Disclosure** do not demand a private story
- **Boundaries** do not remove accountability
- **Specialist care** do not attempt to replace it

Notice → support → refer. Keep the student's privacy, dignity and future options intact.

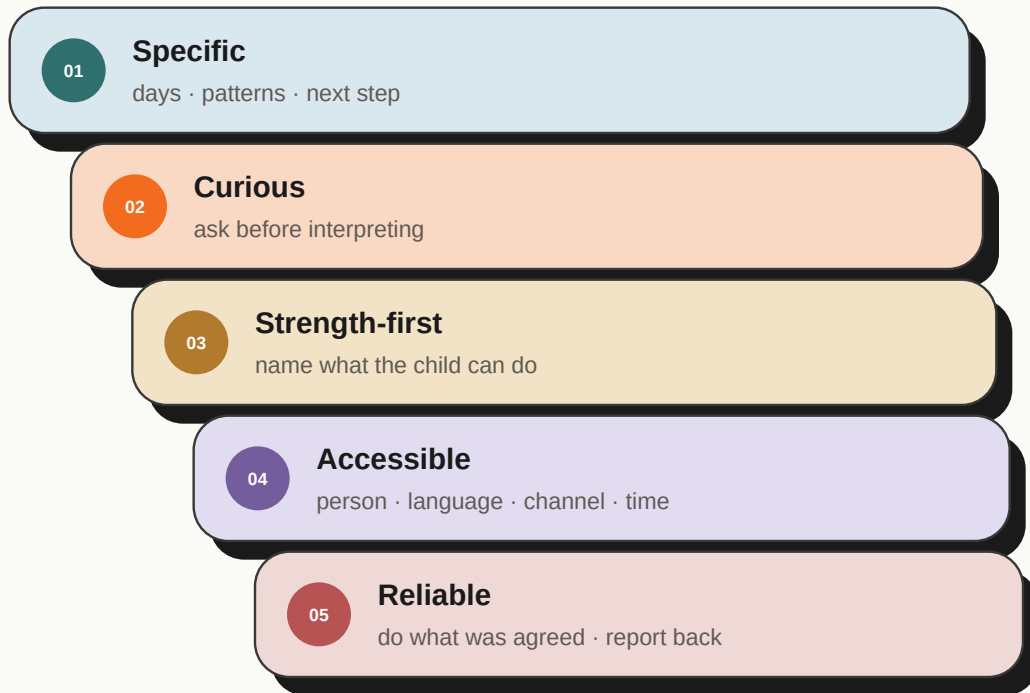
20 days is a reporting threshold. Support starts sooner.



Use days missed, not only percentages. Be specific. Stay curious about the cause.

Partnership is designed before it is declared.

FIVE HABITS THAT MAKE CONTACT REACHABLE

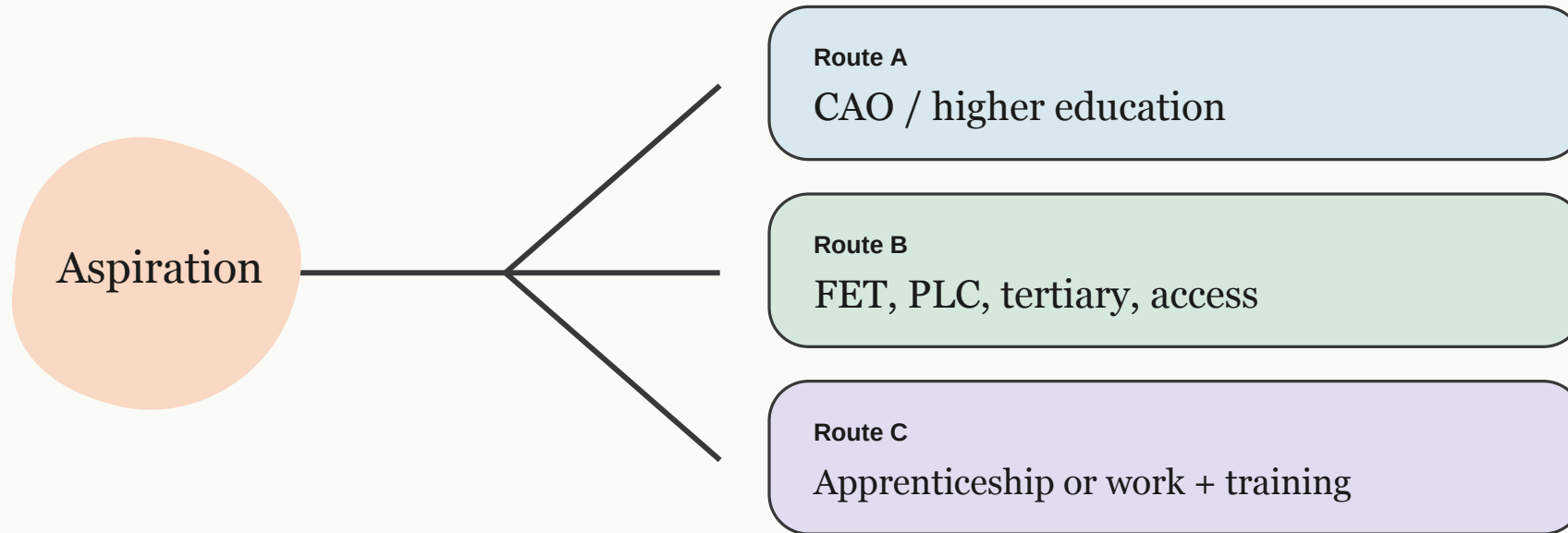


A STRONGER FIRST CONTACT

“We have missed Sam on seven mornings. Sam’s oral answers in Science are strong. Is transport, sleep, caring, anxiety - or something else - making mornings harder?”

“Can we agree one step and check in on Friday?”

A pathway is only real when a student can navigate it.



Each route needs · entry requirements · deadlines · cost/funding · a named adult · family understanding · a next action

Leah is capable. School is becoming harder to reach.

LEAH · FIFTH YEAR

Strong oral contributions. Written work is inconsistent. Sixteen days absent by February and often late. She helps care for younger siblings. She says she wants physiotherapy, then adds: “Courses like that are for people with money.”

IN GROUPS

01

What might the school wrongly infer?

02

What do we need to learn from Leah and home?

03

What changes tomorrow, this term and this year?

04

Who owns each next step?

Coordinate the supports around the student.

01 Known

Named check-in; ask Leah what is changing and what helps.

02 Taught

Model written responses; prioritised catch-up after absence.

03 Present

Map caring/morning barriers; agree a small plan; review weekly.

04 Partnered

Strength-first family conversation; practical constraints first.

05 Future-ready

Physio Route A; related FET/tertiary Route B; funding + HEAR check.

Shared · sequenced · reviewed. One owner, one next step, one date to learn.

How dependable are the five promises?

01

Known

Can every student name an adult who will notice?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

02

Taught

Does support preserve challenge and future options?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

03

Present

Are patterns acted on before 20 days?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

04

Partnered

Can families reach a person, not only a portal?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

05

Future-ready

Does every student have A, B and C routes?

1 · rarely4 · dependable

Rate the system. Then listen for where students and families would score it differently.

One 90-day test beats a 30-page aspiration.

PROMISE

Which student experience will become more dependable?

FOCUS

For whom, where and when is the gap most visible?

ROUTINE

What will adults do differently and how often?

OWNER

Who coordinates, supports and follows through?

EARLY SIGNAL

What should move before outcomes move?

REVIEW

What date will the team learn and adapt?

Small enough to implement. Important enough to matter. Specific enough to learn from.

Track access before outcomes arrive.

WHAT WE CAN SEE IN WEEKS

WHAT WE HOPE TO SHIFT OVER TIME

CAN INFLUENCE

01	students with a named adult		●	attendance and punctuality
02	timely check-ins after emerging absence		●	engagement and belonging
03	family contacts that end with an agreed step		●	attainment and subject-level access
04	students with three mapped pathways		●	retention to Leaving Certificate
05	staff using the agreed teaching routine		●	progression to HE, FET, apprenticeship or work

Privacy boundary: measure support and access - never a student's private trauma history.

Stop. Start. Protect.



STOP

One routine or phrase that quietly closes a door.



START

One action the school will test for 90 days.



PROTECT

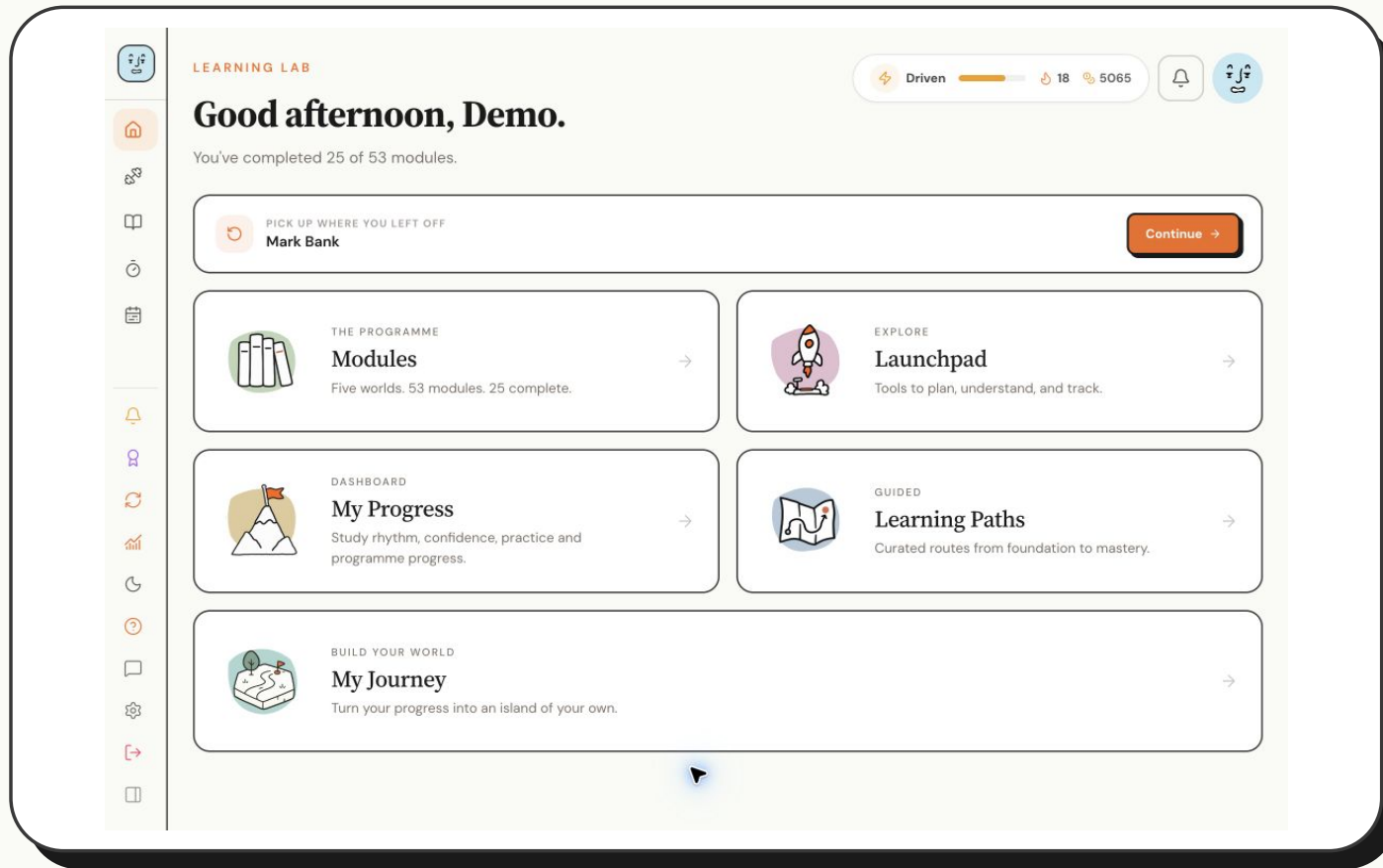
One strength already changing students' odds.

Five moves by Friday.

- | | | |
|----|----------|---|
| 01 | Name | the students at the edge - and the adult who will notice. |
| 02 | Contact | one family with a strength before the concern. |
| 03 | Audit | one task for hidden vocabulary, steps or assumed support. |
| 04 | Map | A, B and C routes with one student. |
| 05 | Schedule | the 90-day review before momentum fades. |

Momentum is a design choice.

The app should strengthen a human support system.



FIVE DEPENDABLE EXPERIENCES

TEACH

Modules

make methods explicit

CHOOSE

Launchpad

match tool to need

NOTICE

My Progress

see patterns over time

SEQUENCE

Learning Paths

make the next step clear

BELONG

My Journey

turn growth into a place

Teach the method before asking for independence.

03 — THE CHEAT CODES

Learn

Techniques that compound

Active recall, spaced repetition, interleaving — the practical strategies that separate high performers.

9 60% complete
15 modules in this world

CONTINUE WHERE YOU LEFT OFF

Focused vs Diffuse Mode

The Bimodal Brain

Your brain has two modes — one for grinding through problems, one for creative breakthroughs. Learning when to switch between them is a game-changer for your...

UP NEXT · SECTION 5 OF 6

Why We Put Things Off

Continue →

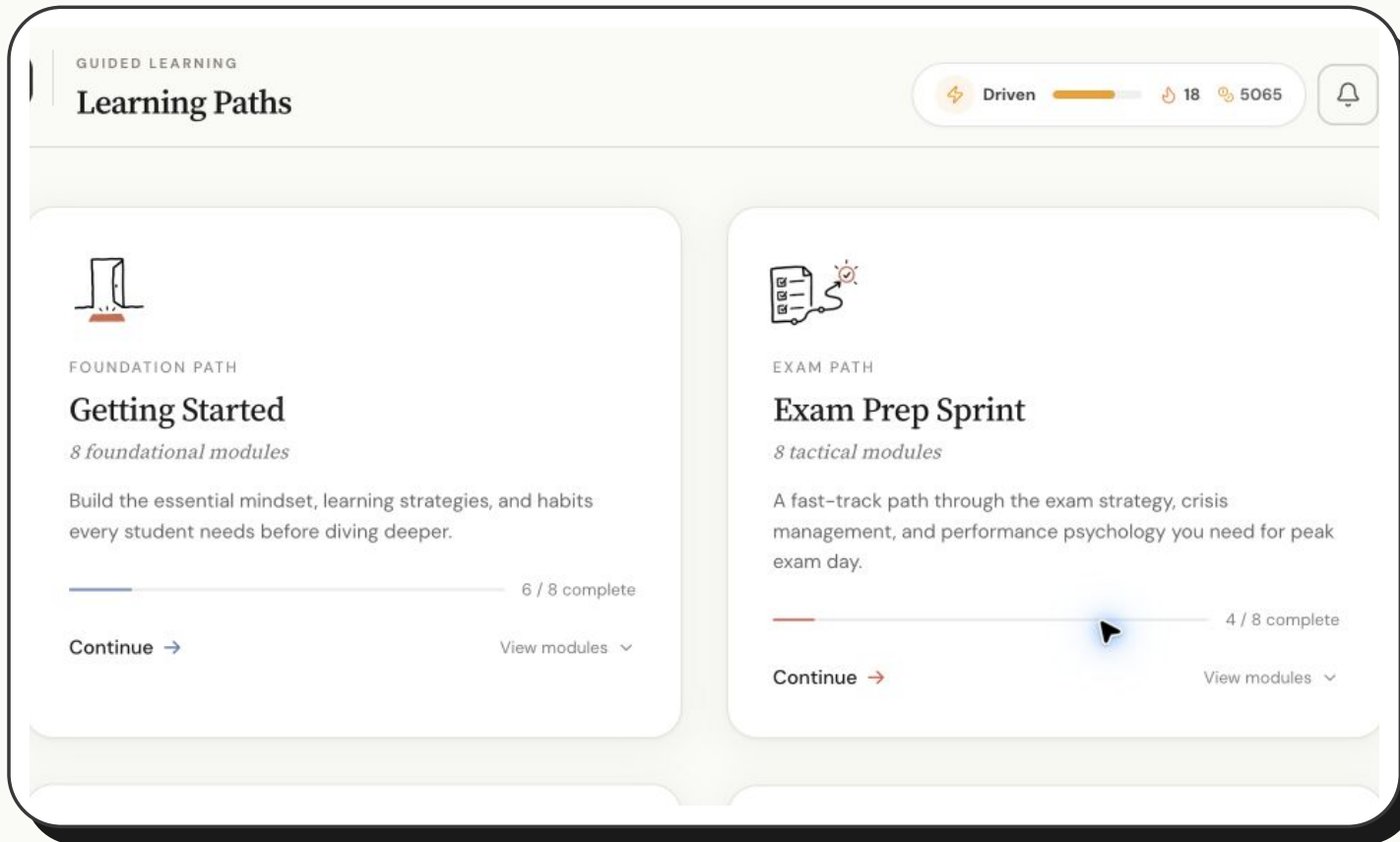
Browse all 15 >

TRANSFER NEEDS ADULT ACTION

- 01 Explain**
teach one strategy explicitly
- 02 Model**
use real subject content
- 03 Choose**
name when and why it fits
- 04 Fade**
revisit until support can reduce

Completion starts transfer; it does not prove it.

A pathway makes the next step visible without shrinking ambition.



FOUR LIVE ROUTES

FOUNDATION

stabilise habits and core strategies

EXAM

make tactical preparation explicit

MINDSET

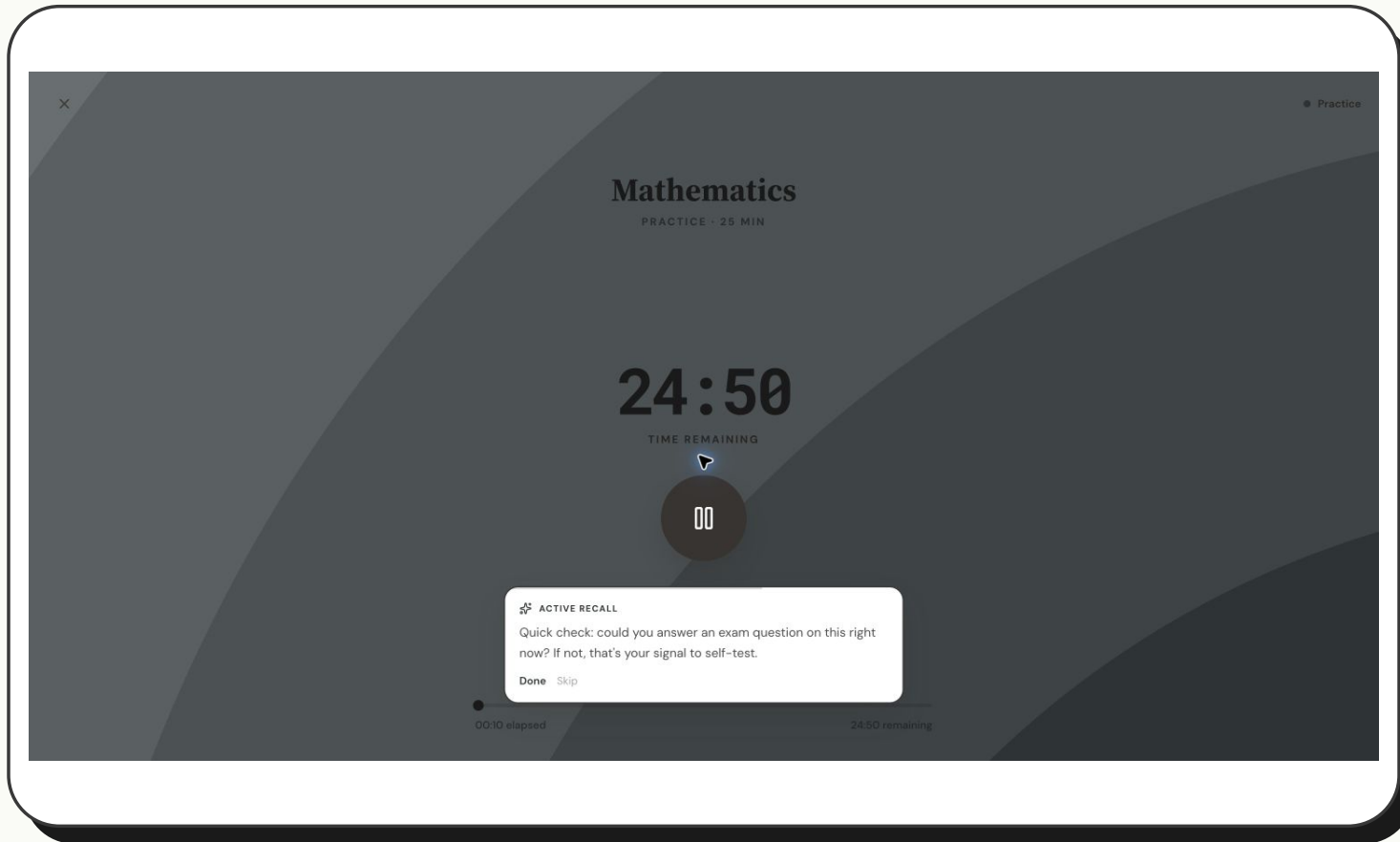
develop resilience and self-knowledge

LEARNING

sequence evidence-based study methods

Sequence support. Never hide prerequisites.

Make the next study session easy to begin.



BEFORE THE TIMER

TARGET

What will be produced?

METHOD

Retrieve, solve or explain.

CHECK

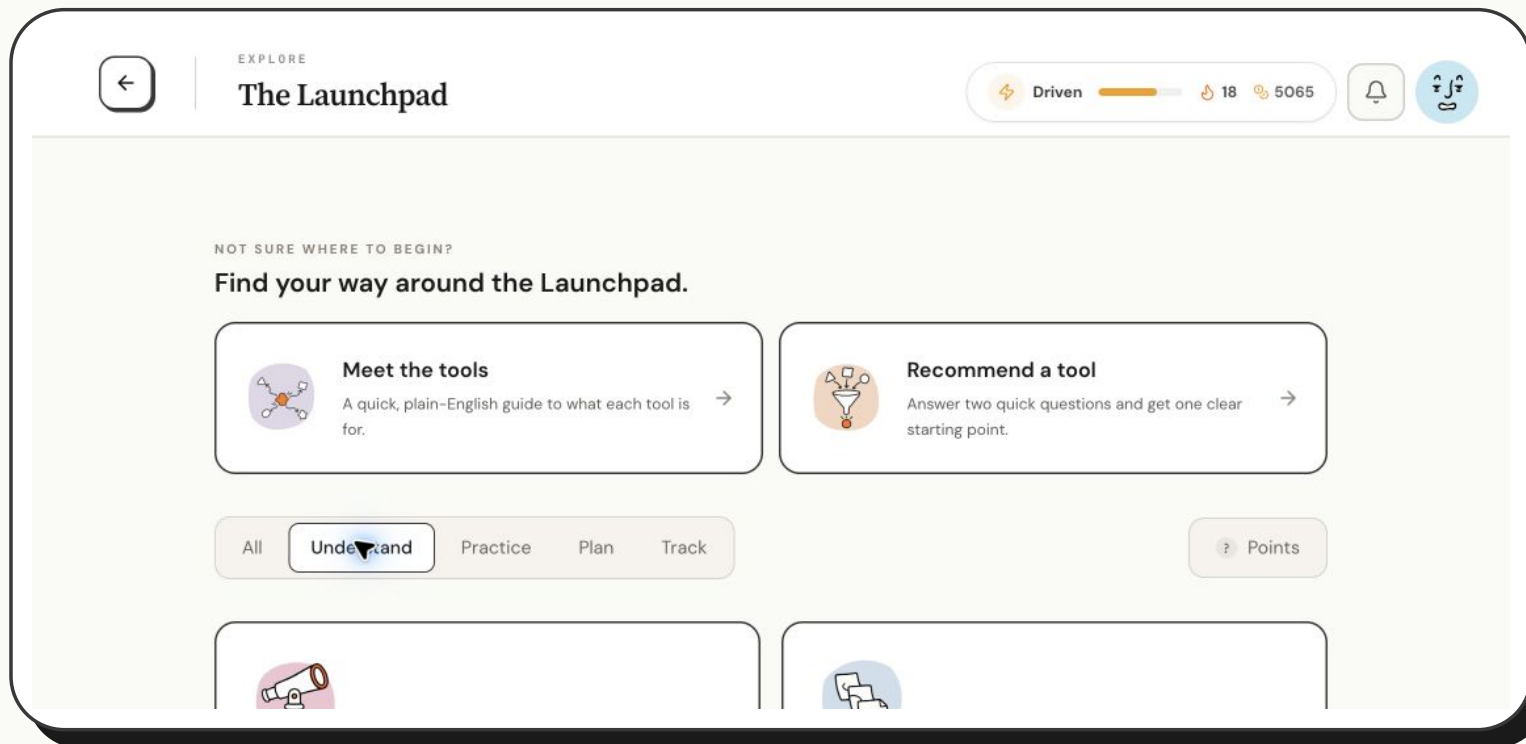
What proves accuracy?

RETURN

What comes back, when?

Time protects attention. The task creates evidence.

Make demanding material and possible futures easier to enter.

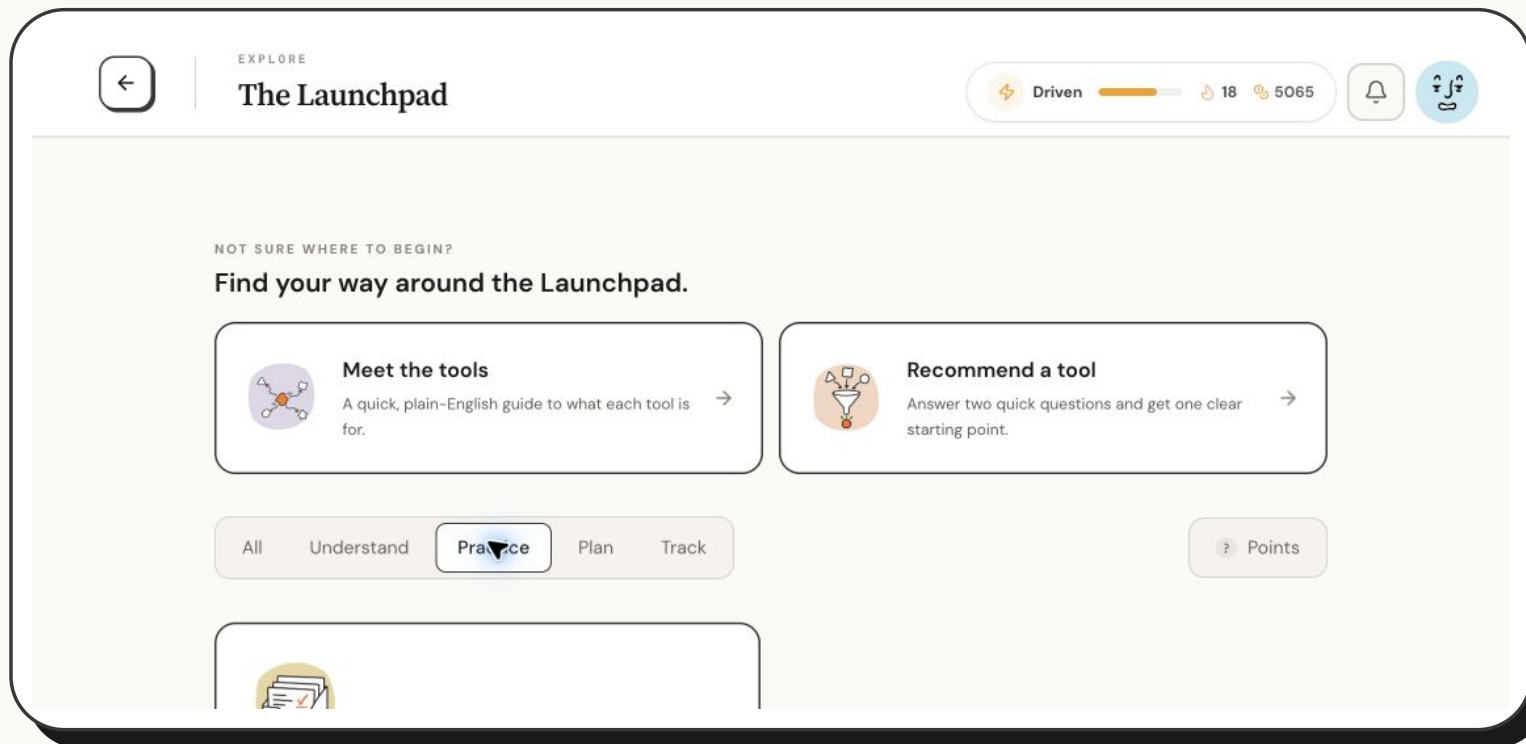


LIVE TOOLS · UNDERSTAND

- Future Finder**
widen career possibilities
- Paper Trail**
open real SEC papers
- Command-Word Reflex**
decode the demanded action
- How They Did It**
make pathways relatable
- Your Possible Life**
test real career trade-offs

Adult role: choose for need · agree the output · review the next move.

Turn effort into feedback, repair and another attempt.



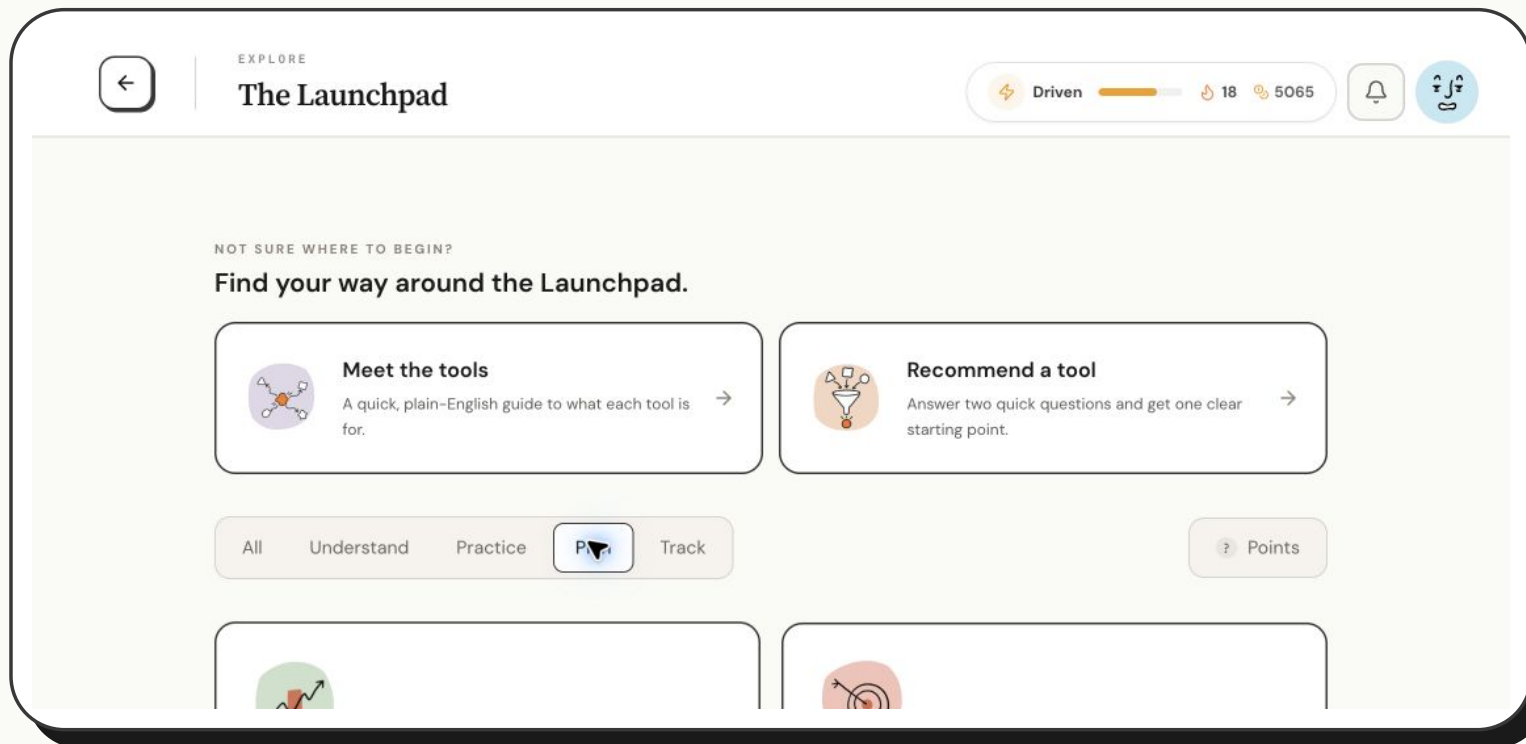
THE REPAIR LOOP

Mark Bank

- 01 **Attempt** without notes
- 02 **Compare** with the scheme
- 03 **Repair** the first error
- 04 **Return** after a gap

Adult role: choose for need · agree the output · review the next move.

Protect continuity when time, confidence or attendance slips.

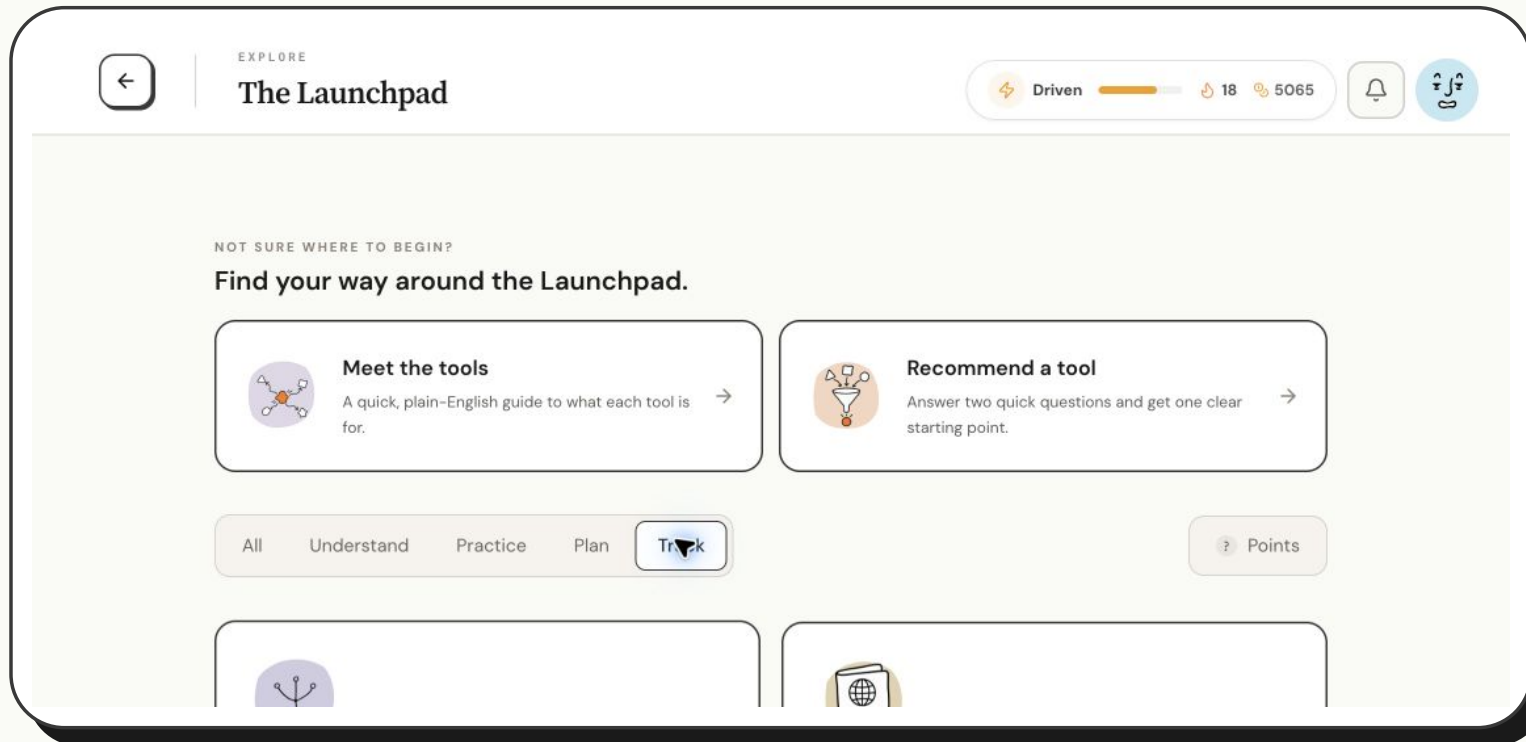


A CONTINUITY MAP

- Spaced Repetition Timetable**
schedule useful returns
- War Room**
choose priorities
- Comeback Engine**
plan a dignified recovery
- College Compass**
keep routes and deadlines visible
- Catch-Up Lane**
replace backlog with one next step

Adult role: choose for need · agree the output · review the next move.

Make choices, routes and progress discussable.



LIVE TOOLS · TRACK

Academic Journey Simulator

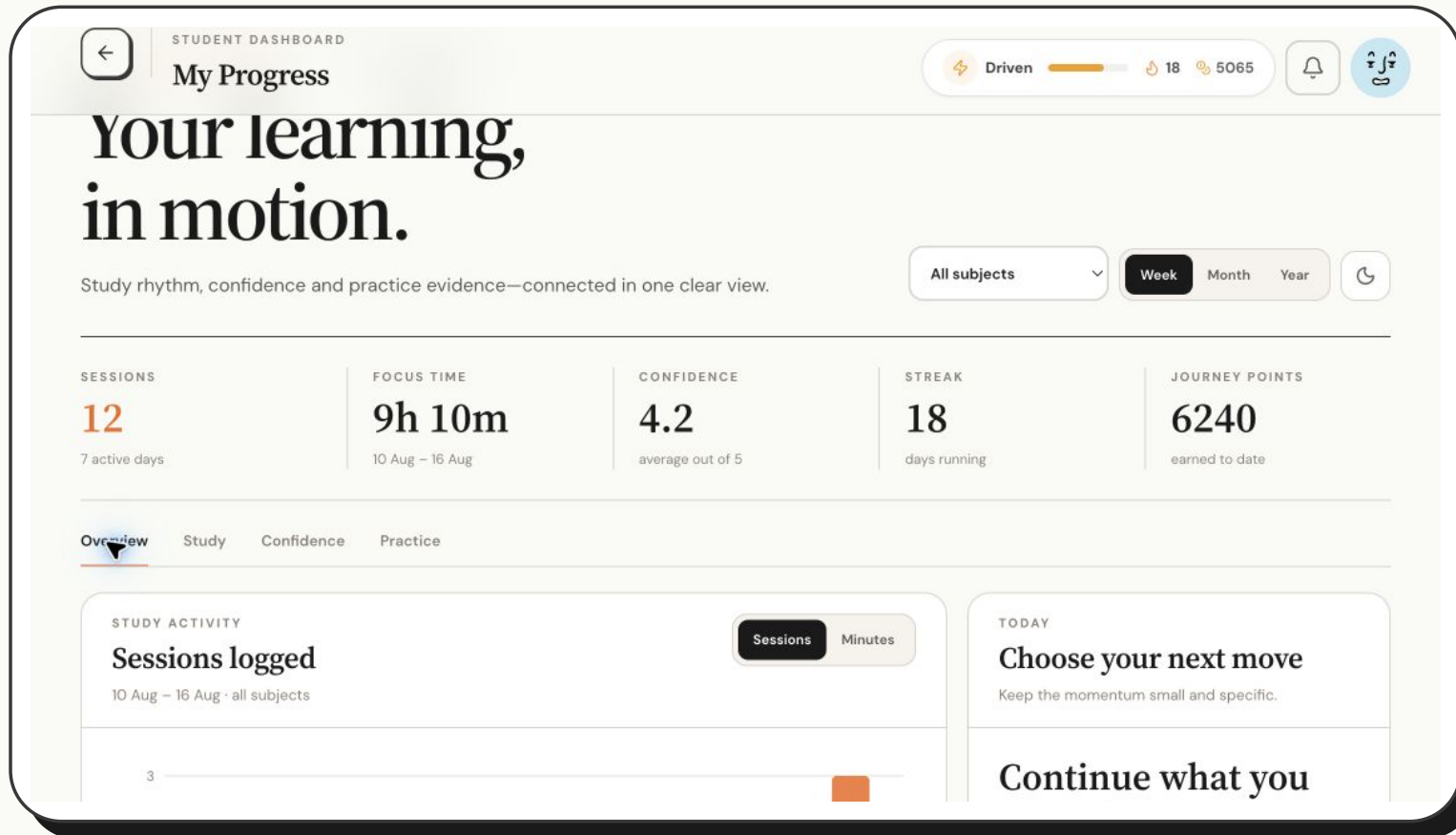
rehearse choices safely

Points Passport

see trends and possible gains

Adult role: choose for need · agree the output · review the next move.

A dashboard should start a conversation - not issue a verdict.



USE THE FILTERS, THEN ASK

01 **What changed?**
Compare week, month and year.

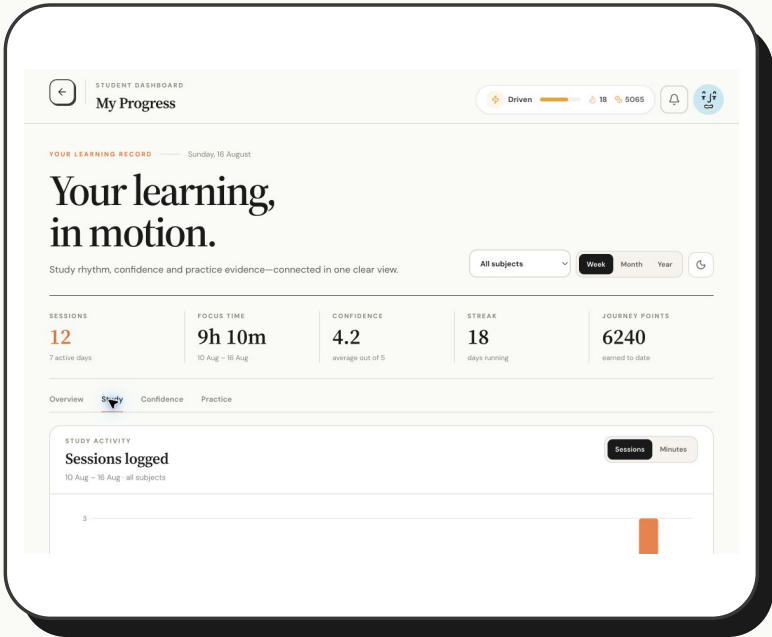
02 **What helped?**
Connect rhythm to method and access.

03 **Where is it stuck?**
Look for a barrier, not a defect.

04 **What happens next?**
Name an action and an adult.

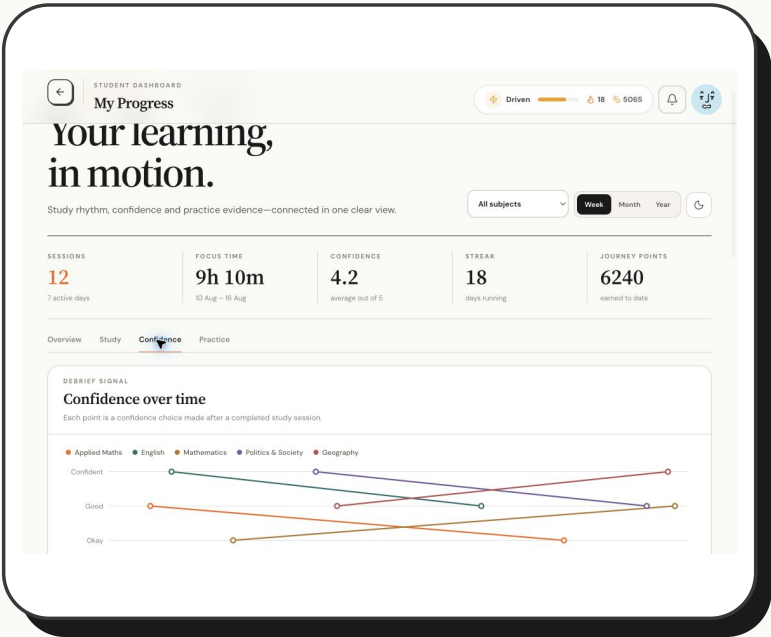
Patterns guide support. They do not predict worth.

Rhythm, confidence and practice stay connected.



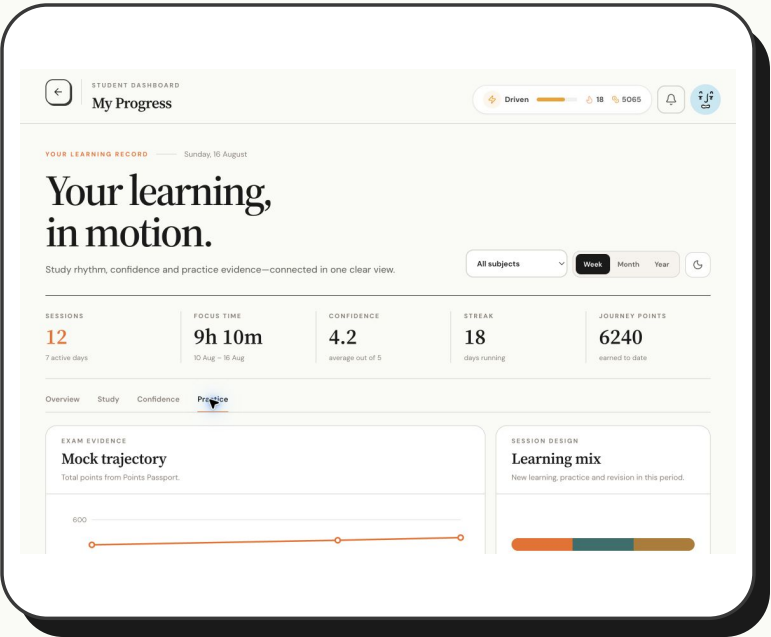
STUDY

Is effort becoming a dependable rhythm?



CONFIDENCE

What is the student noticing about readiness?



PRACTICE

Is work producing exam evidence and repair?

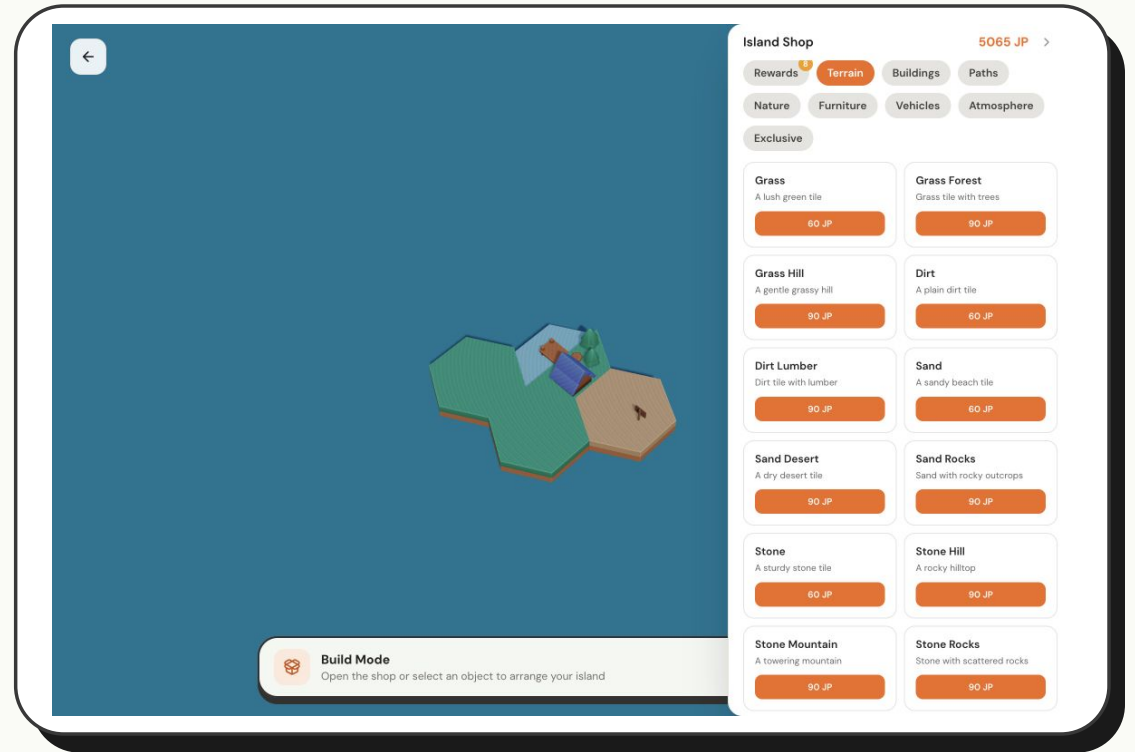
Let progress become a place the student can shape.

JOURNEY MODE



Journey: accumulated effort becomes a place and a story.

BUILD MODE

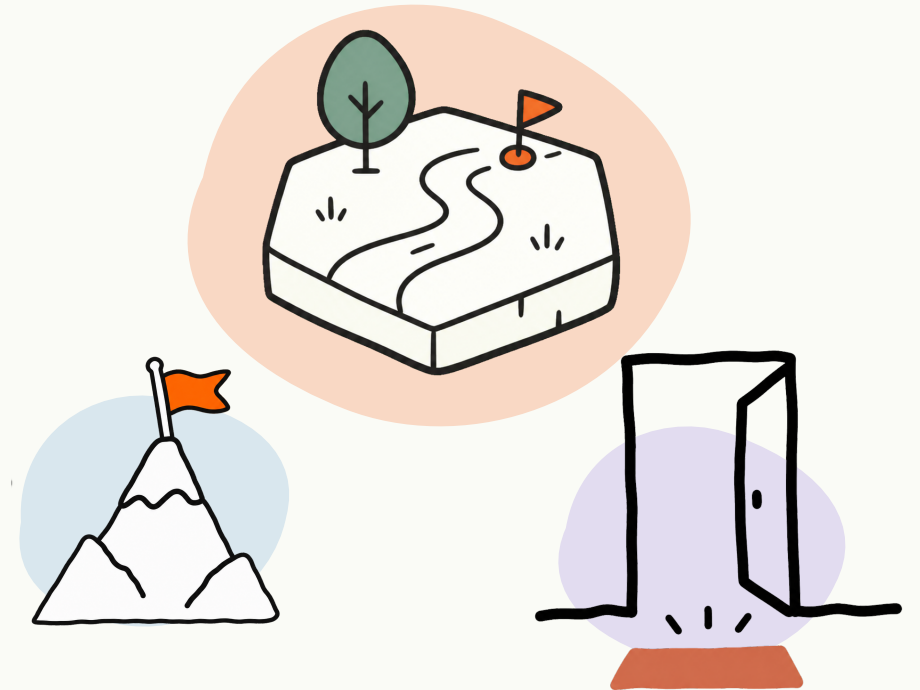


Build: meaningful choice adds authorship without public ranking.

Be the school that keeps the door open.

Not every barrier begins in school.

But school can decide whether a barrier becomes a ceiling.



National statistics and policy sources.

CSO	SILC Module on Child Deprivation 2024	https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-silccd/silcmoduleonchilddeprivation2024/keyfindings/
Tusla	Analysis of School Attendance Data 2023/24	https://www.tusla.ie/uploads/content/Analysis_of_School_Attendance_Data_2023-24.pdf
Department of Education	DEIS Strategy to 2035; retention and attendance material	https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-education/publications/deis-strategy-to-2035/
OECD	PISA 2022 Results - Ireland country note	https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/pisa-2022-results-volume-i-and-ii-country-notes_ed6fbcc5-en/ireland_01173012-en.html
HEA	Socio-economic profiles of students, 2021/22-2023/24	https://hea.ie/statistics/data-for-download-and-visualisations/students/widening-participation-for-equity-of-access/socio-economic-profiles-2021-22-2023-24/student-profile/
ESRI / GUI	Self-concept, expectations and teacher-student relationships	https://www.esri.ie/publications/how-are-childrens-academic-self-concepts-their-parents-expectations-and-their
OECD	Review of Resourcing Schools to Address Educational Disadvantage in Ireland	https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-review-of-resourcing-schools-to-address-educational-disadvantage-in-ireland_3433784c-en.html

Teaching, attendance, trauma and pathways.

NEPS	Service, Continuum of Support and trauma resources	https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-education/collections/national-educational-psychological-service-neps-resources-and-publications/
EEF	Metacognition and self-regulation; feedback	https://educationendowmentfoundation.org.uk/education-evidence/teaching-learning-toolkit/metacognition-and-self-regulation
IES / WWC	Organizing Instruction and Study to Improve Student Learning	https://ies.ed.gov/ncee/wwc/PracticeGuide/1
Department of Education	How to create study routines for the Leaving Certificate	https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-education/publications/how-to-create-study-routines-for-the-leaving-certificate-during-the-covid-19-pandemic/
EEF	Attendance interventions evidence summary	https://educationendowmentfoundation.org.uk/education-evidence/leadership-and-planning/supporting-attendance/summary-of-evidence
Campbell systematic review	Effects of trauma-informed approaches in schools	https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8356508/
UK Government	Caution on use of ACE screening tools	https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/trauma-informed-practice-learning-from-experience/trauma-informed-practice-learning-from-experience-of-violence-reduction-unit-delivery-2021-to-2023-accessible
DFHERIS	Education pathways in Ireland	https://www.gov.ie/en/department-of-further-and-higher-education-research-innovation-and-science/press-releases/ministers-lawless-and-harkin-urg-e-all-learners-to-explore-the-unprecedented-number-of-education-pathways-now-available/
Access College / SUSI	HEAR and student grant information	https://accesscollege.ie/hear/how-do-i-apply/eligibility-criteria/